

AUDITIONS AND ASSERTIONS



India A's **red-ball audition** in Lucknow saw Padikkal, Sudharsan and Jurel step up, as Rahul reminded of his class before a busy Test season.

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Futures, vacancies, and subplots within the Indian Test squad were the main talking points when India A hosted Australia A for two four-day games in Lucknow.

For some, like K. L. Rahul, Mohammed Siraj, Nitish Kumar Reddy, and Dhruv Jurel, the series was primarily about valuable game time. For others, it was an audition — a chance to stake a claim for the upcoming four home Tests against West Indies and South Africa.

Iyer's absence, Padikkal's gain

The biggest headline, however, was Shreyas Iyer's unavailability for red-ball cricket over the next six months due to recurring back issues.

Named captain for the series, Iyer could have made a strong case for himself in the middle order. Instead, he lasted just 13 balls in the opening game before flying home.

"Having undergone back surgery in the UK and managed his recovery well, he has recently experienced recurring back spasms and stiffness while playing the longer format. He wishes to utilise this period to build endurance, body resilience, and work on his fitness," the BCCI explained.

Iyer's absence opened the door for Devdutt Padikkal, and the Karnataka left-hander stepped through with authority. His fluent 150 in the first match was more than just runs — it was a statement of

temperament and patience. He mixed crisp cover drives with watchful leaves outside off stump and, most importantly, showed the patience to bat long. By the time the selectors announced India's squad for the West Indies Tests, Padikkal's name had been firmly cemented. "We feel Padikkal offers a little bit more [than Karun Nair] at this point," chief selector Ajit Agarkar said.

Discipline

If Padikkal made the breakthrough, Sai Sudharsan provided the confirmation. The Tamil Nadu southpaw topped the run charts with 248 and emerged as the most composed batter on either side. His game carries a stillness —